

Seven Hebrew Words Every Christian Should Know

אָמֵן • הַלְלוּיָהּ • רוּחַ • תְּשׁוּבָה • אֲמוּנָה • חֶסֶד • שְׁלוֹם

Rabbi Evan Moffic

For readers of *One Word Wiser*

I'm a rabbi. For years I've read the Hebrew Bible with Christians, in churches, in living rooms, over coffee, and we keep finding the same thing. The Hebrew Bible most of us read is a translation, and a good one. But every translation has to pick one English word where the Hebrew holds three.

Hear the Hebrew once, and a verse you've read a hundred times opens a little wider. Nothing is taken away. Something is added.

Here are seven words. You say some of them already. Say each one out loud, then read the verse. That's all.

— *Rabbi Evan*

שָׁלוֹם

shalom

PEACE, WHOLENESS

SAY IT. *Sha-LOME*. The stress on the second syllable, the *o* long, as in *home*.

THE PICTURE. *Shalom* comes from *shalem*: whole, complete, nothing missing. A wall with no gap in it is *shalem*. The verb for paying off a debt comes from the same root. So peace, in Hebrew, was never just quiet. It is the state of a thing with all its parts. When two people make *shalom*, they aren't calling a truce. They are being made whole again, together.

ONE VERSE.

— The LORD turn his face toward you and give you peace. (Numbers 6:26)

The word under "peace" is *shalom*. It is the last line of the priestly blessing, still spoken in synagogues and churches, and notice what it ends on. Light, grace, the lifted face, and then *shalom*, the thing that holds all the rest.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. On the evening of the first Easter, Jesus stands in a locked room and says one word to his frightened friends: "Peace be with you!" (John 20:19). The Greek word there is the one the Greek translation of the Hebrew Bible uses for *shalom*, and under it is the greeting every Jew said then and says now: *shalom aleichem*. Not "calm down." Be whole.

Peace is not quiet. Peace is nothing missing.



LOYAL LOVE

SAY IT. *CHEH-sed*. The first sound comes from the back of the throat, like the *ch* in Bach. Stress on the first syllable.

THE PICTURE. English has never found the word. Translators say "mercy," "lovingkindness," "steadfast love," sometimes just "love," and each one gets a piece. *Chesed* is love that keeps its promises. Love with a spine. It is what Ruth does when she refuses to leave Naomi; the book of Ruth names it three times. Not a feeling that comes over you. A loyalty you act on, especially when no one would blame you for walking away.

ONE VERSE.

Give thanks to the LORD, for he is good. His love endures forever. (Psalm 136:1)

The word under "love" is *chesed*, and the psalm says the line twenty-six times: *ki l'olam chasdo*. It is a refrain because *chesed* is the thing that repeats.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus quotes Hosea to the Pharisees, twice: "I desire mercy, not sacrifice" (Matthew 9:13; 12:7). The word under "mercy" in Hosea 6:6 is *chesed*. He isn't asking them to feel sorrier. He is asking for loyal love.

Chesed is love that shows up again tomorrow.



FAITH, STEADINESS

SAY IT. *Eh-moo-NAH*. Stress at the end. Say *amen* right after it and hear the same root.

THE PICTURE. *Emunah* comes from *aman*: firm, steady, something you can lean your weight on. A nurse who carries a child is an *omen* in Hebrew, from the same root, because the child is safe in those arms (Numbers 11:12). In Exodus, Moses stands on a hill with his hands raised over the battle below. When his arms tire, two men hold them up, "so that his hands remained steady till sunset" (Exodus 17:12). The word under "steady" is *emunah*, the first time the Hebrew Bible uses it. Not a belief he held. Hands that were held.

ONE VERSE.

— The righteous person will live by his faithfulness. (Habakkuk 2:4)

The word under "faithfulness" is *emunah*. Not certainty. Steadiness.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. That line is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38), and it became the sentence the Reformation was built on: "The righteous will live by faith." Faith, faithfulness: in Hebrew they are one word, and the picture behind it is a hand held steady until sunset.

Faith, in Hebrew, is hands held steady until the sun goes down.

תשובה

teshuvah

RETURN

SAY IT. *Teh-shoo-VAH*. Stress on the last syllable, like a step landing on a doorstep.

THE PICTURE. The English word is "repentance." Set it down. *Teshuvah* grows from *shuv*, to turn around, to come back, one of the most common verbs in the Hebrew Bible, and almost always physical. The dove comes back to Noah's ark; the word is *shuv*. Naomi comes home to Bethlehem; *shuv* again. Repentance, in English, is a feeling, from a Latin word for penalty. *Teshuvah* is a direction. You were walking one way. You turn around. You walk back. Nobody asks how bad you feel. They ask which way you are facing.

ONE VERSE.

When you and your children return to the LORD your God and obey him with all your heart and with all your soul... (Deuteronomy 30:2)

The word under "return" is *shuv*, *teshuvah*'s root. The Torah says it as a promise: you will come back.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. The first word of Jesus's preaching is "Repent" (Mark 1:15). In Hebrew ears that is *shuvu*: turn around, come home. And the son in Luke 15 doesn't feel his way back to his father. "He got up and went" (Luke 15:20).

You don't have to feel worse. You have to face the other way.

רוּחַ

ruach

WIND, BREATH, SPIRIT

SAY IT. *ROO-ach*. The last sound scrapes the back of the throat; let it. One syllable and a half.

THE PICTURE. One word, three meanings, and the Hebrew never chooses. *Ruach* is the wind that moves the trees, the breath that moves your chest, and the Spirit that moves over the deep. Every translator has to pick one. The Hebrew reader gets all three at once. In Ezekiel's valley of dry bones, the prophet calls, "Come, breath, from the four winds" (Ezekiel 37:9). "Breath" and "winds" are the same word there, *ruach*, and the bones stand up.

ONE VERSE.

And the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters. (Genesis 1:2)

The word under "Spirit" is *ruach*. The second verse of the Hebrew Bible, before light: wind, or breath, or Spirit. The Hebrew won't say which, because it is all three.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus tells Nicodemus, "The wind blows wherever it pleases... So it is with everyone born of the Spirit" (John 3:8). In Greek, as in Hebrew, that is one word doing both jobs. The sentence is a play on *ruach*, and it only works if you hear the double meaning.

Wind, breath, Spirit. The Hebrew won't choose, so you get all three.

הללויה

hallelujah

PRAISE THE LORD

SAY IT. *Ha-le-LOO-yah*. You already know how. It is the one Hebrew word the Church never translated.

THE PICTURE. It is not one word but two. *Hallelu* is a command in the plural: praise, all of you. *Yah* is the short form of God's name, the one hiding inside *Isaiah* and *Elijah*. So *hallelujah* is not a sigh of happiness. It is an order given to a crowd: praise Him, everyone. The last five psalms each open and close with it, like a doorframe. And it crossed into Greek, then Latin, then English, letter for letter, because no one could find a better word.

ONE VERSE.

Let everything that has breath praise the LORD. Praise the LORD. (Psalm 150:6)

That last "Praise the LORD" is *hallelujah*, the final word of the final psalm. And "everything that has breath" is *kol haneshamah*: every breath, every soul, every thing that breathes.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Handel took the word from Revelation 19, the only place the New Testament says it: "Hallelujah! For our Lord God Almighty reigns" (Revelation 19:6). John wrote it in Greek letters, but the word he wrote was Hebrew.

Hallelujah is a command, given to a crowd: praise Him, all of you.

אָמֵן

amen

SO BE IT

SAY IT. *Ab-MEN*. Stress at the end. However your church says it, you are saying Hebrew.

THE PICTURE. *Amen* is *emunah*'s little brother, from the same root, *aman*: firm, steady, trustworthy. To say *amen* is not to say "the end." It is to say "I stand on that." In the Hebrew Bible it is an answer. Someone else speaks first, a blessing or a vow, and the people answer *amen*: we take it as ours. That is why one voice says the blessing and the whole room says the last word.

ONE VERSE.

Then all the people shall say, "Amen!" (Deuteronomy 27:15)

Twelve times on Mount Ebal the Levites call out, and twelve times the whole people answer with one word.

WHERE YOU ALREADY SAY IT. Jesus turns the word around. In the Hebrew Bible, *amen* answers; someone else speaks first. Jesus opens with it: "Very truly I tell you" is *amen*, *amen* in the Greek (John 1:51, and twenty-four more times in John). He is saying: stand on this. And Revelation gives him the word as a name: "the Amen, the faithful and true witness" (Revelation 3:14).

Amen doesn't mean "the end." It means "I stand on that."

One Hebrew word arrives every morning at rabbi.substack.com.

Send me a verse. Any verse. I'll show you the Hebrew underneath.

— *Rabbi Evan*

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